

regressive step.

S.N. SHARMA, *Gurgaon*

Your cover story elucidates the sinister motive of a few politicians, who want to cash in on the caste issue to woo their voters. No one believes Sushma Swaraj when she justifies the caste count to further academic interests. In comparison to the Census 1931, this time the ratio of higher caste is bound to be less than the reserve category, because of smaller family norms prevalent in the group. However, are they going to get penalised for that? Does it mean that the outcome of Census is going to give a signal, which is anti-family planning?

MANJULA PAL,

Delhi

Tighten the Noose

I'm appalled at the views of some people who feel death sentence should not have been given to Ajmal Kasab on the grounds that by taking away a person's life we are committing the same crime that the accused did ("26/11: The Inside Story", May 17).

There cannot be a parallel between the two acts. We the tax payers are spending Rs 2 lakh a day to keep alive a person who has committed a heinous crime. Over a lifetime we will end up spending more than a hundred crore. While innocent farmers are committing suicide because they cannot afford

even one square meal a day, we have no qualms in spending our hard-earned money for keeping Kasab alive. If we feel too strongly about not taking lives then we can deport him to Pakistan, swapping him with an Indian who is awaiting the gallows there. MOHAN NARAYANAN, via www.indiatoday.in

Changing Ballgame

India's performance in the World Twenty20 was totally dismal and disgraceful ("Short Circuit",

country. No player should be selected on the basis of his past laurels. Likewise, the so-called tired players should take rest to make way for the newcomers. The game is more important than the players.

PREM K. MENON, *Mumbai*

Cost of Callousness

It is shocking how a defective bulletproof jacket could be given an approval for use ("Playing with Lives", May 24). Similarly, fake drugs, including life-saving ones, are illegally



“ Schools are responsible for inculcating sound values among children (“The De-School Brigade”, May 24). De-schooling, however, would only deprive children of this experience. ”

AMIT BRAHMO, *Kolkata*

May 24). When an entire bunch of players fail in a tournament, something is drastically wrong also with the selectors who chose a team that could not deliver goods. It's a grave injustice to select unfit players when there is no dearth of talent in the

manufactured and marketed in connivance with a predatory bureaucracy. The test of Manmohan Singh's leadership will lie not so much in his survival strategies as in his actions to curb official graft.

KANGAYAM R. NARASIMHAN, *Chennai*

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30
YEARS
AGO IN
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AUGUST 1-15, 1980

The Elusive King of Con

Mithilesh Kumar Srivastava, before he was much older, was to become better known by another name—Natwarlal. In the movie based on some of his exploits, Natwarlal was played by the dashing superstar, Amitabh Bachchan. In real life, however, he is a short (5 ft), stocky individual with receding grey hair and a protruding pot belly. But like Bachchan, though in an entirely different field, he has become legend in his lifetime. A con man par excellence, a master forger, an escape artist to rival Houdini, who has publicly boasted that no jail ever built can keep him inside for more than a year. His first sentence in Calcutta was six months rigorous imprisonment. He had barely been released, when he was arrested once again for fraud and given a longer sentence—eight months. He served out his time, and decided to shift operations to Madras. *by Dilip Bobb with Farzand Ahmed and Lalitha Subramaniam*



NATWARLAL